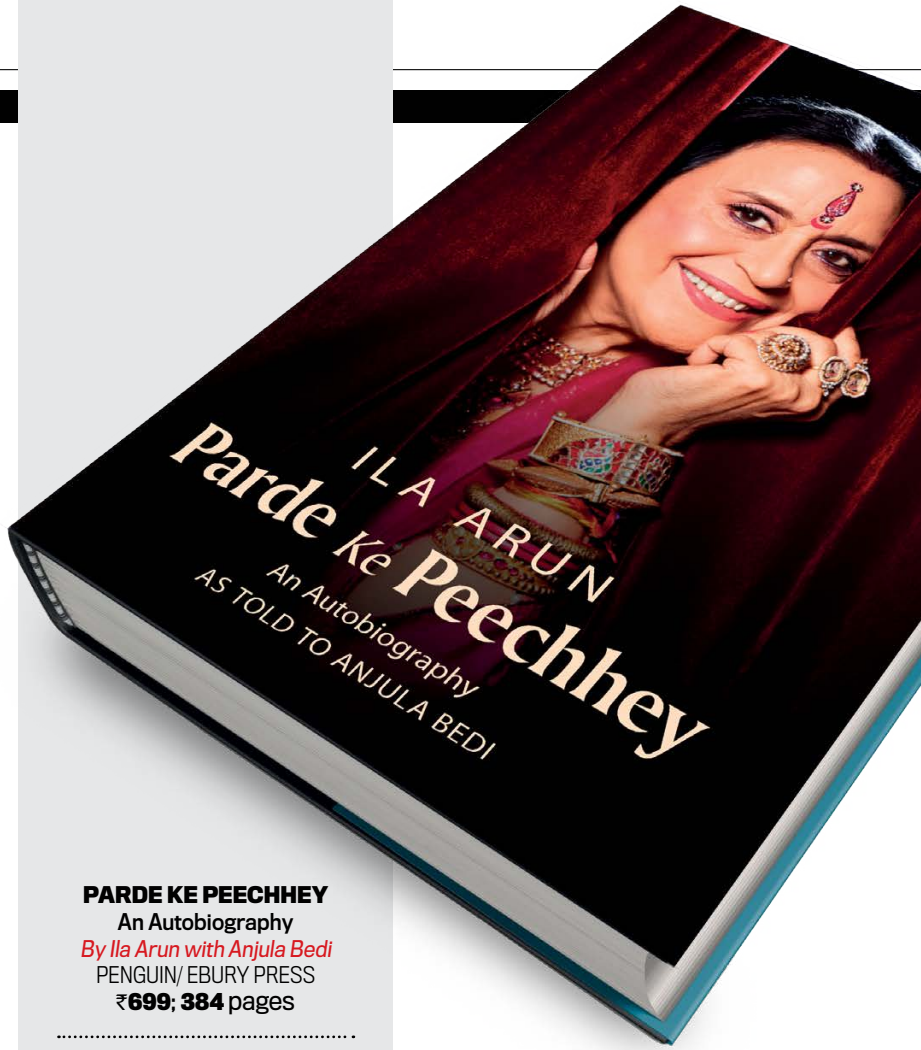


PARDE KE PEECHHEY
An Autobiography
By Ila Arun with Anjula Bedi
PENGUIN/ EBURY PRESS
₹**699**; **384** pages

WHAT IS IMPRESSIVE IS THE DEPTH AND BREADTH OF ARUN'S MEMORY BANK, OBVIOUSLY BUOYED BY HER ENTHUSIASM FOR THE PROJECT

The most impressive aspect of Ila Arun's self-assessment as an author must be that she knows she has style.

"All paintings can have the sun, the moon, clouds and trees," the 70-year-old multihyphenate explains. "But S.H. Raza is immediately identified as S.H. Raza because of what he does with the black dot. It's the same for M.F. Husain or Anjolie Ela Menon. Everybody has a lot to say. But the question is how are you saying it? How will you use flashforward or flashback? What memory will another memory open into?"

Throughout her newly published autobiography, *Parde ke Peechhey*, co-written with her theatre colleague Anjula Bedi, Arun slips into fantasies, daydreaming and intricate detailing within her memories, occasionally sprinkled with quotes plucked from practically anywhere: Shakespeare, Ramakrishna Paramahansa, Native American Hopis and the Chinese.

"There is an Ila Arun in everything I write," she says. "The pen and I are not new."

While widely known for her Rajasthani folk singing, smartly used in pop hits like 'Choli Ke Peeche' from the 1993 Hindi blockbuster *Khalnayak*, as well as her roles in films like *Jodha Akbar* (2008), Arun has constantly been writing her own lyrics, original plays, and even adapting multiple works by the playwright Henrik Ibsen into Hindi.

Parde Ke Peechhey, which translates to 'behind the curtain', is a reference to her aforementioned sensuous chartbuster. Arun wrote the book over two years in Hindi during the Coronavirus pandemic.

"I never thought that my life was worth writing a book about," Arun recalls. "But people demanded it. During Covid, once I began writing, the memories kept flooding in. And I felt there is no past. Everything is happening in the present. Forty-two years in theatre and 30 in films gave me a lot to write about. There are so many good people I worked with, so many to thank. While finishing the book I realised, if I hadn't written it, I would have left this world unsatisfied."

Bedi, a noted English-language writer and publisher, worked with Arun on the English-language version. Arun says the Hindi version will be out next year.

The book is mostly chronological. It begins with Arun's early days in Jodhpur, moves into her initiation into dancing and theatre, which were an integral part of her Marwari community, followed by her experiences at the National School of Drama in Delhi, stage and, later, the Mumbai film industry as a singer and actor. What is impressive is the depth and breadth of her memory bank, obviously buoyed by her enthusiasm for the project.

Arun recalls having a "sense of loss" on the day of the book launch. "I wrote so many personal things in it," she says. "Was it worth it? I constantly hear that people don't read books anymore, they only scroll. Will my book just make it to scrap collectors? But then I realised, no, I wrote it for myself, and the book is for those who want to slowly discover my work